

The Player-Coach Playbook

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THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Before Lesson 1

Getting Started

Your welcome, your role this season, how your Playbook works, and four things to set up. It takes about 10 minutes, and you only do it once.

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Welcome to the Player-Coach's Corner

Welcome, Player-Coach.

The document you are holding is more than a workbook; it is your command center for this season. While your Athleader is in the arena conditioning their skills, this is your space for strategy, reflection, and growth. You are not just a spectator in their development; you are the most critical member of their coaching staff.

The M.V.P. Accelerator Player-Coach Track is designed with a dual purpose. It will equip you with the frameworks (like A.R.A.W.) and shared language to coach your Athleader through their journey effectively. But just as importantly, it is a dedicated space for you to condition your leadership muscles. We believe that to lead others effectively, you must first lead yourself well. The best coaches are also dedicated players, constantly sharpening their own skills.

Use this Playbook to translate the concepts from the videos into tangible actions. The drills within are designed to be practical, relevant, and immediately applicable to the real-world challenges you face as a leader, from driving team alignment and retaining top talent to managing your own energy and preventing burnout. This is your journey to becoming a more impactful, aligned, and resilient leader.

Use this space in this Playbook to reflect deeply, plan strategically, and commit to action. Right now, establish the time you will commit to make this a priority: block 45-60 minutes on your calendar each week (in one block or across multiple times) and schedule a meeting with yourself to ensure you don't allow anyone else to take this valuable time away from an investment in yourself. This is your journey. Own it.

You've got this!

Melissa

Melissa Dawn Simkins
Founder, Athleadership, and Head Coach

Your role this season

Who is my Athleader?

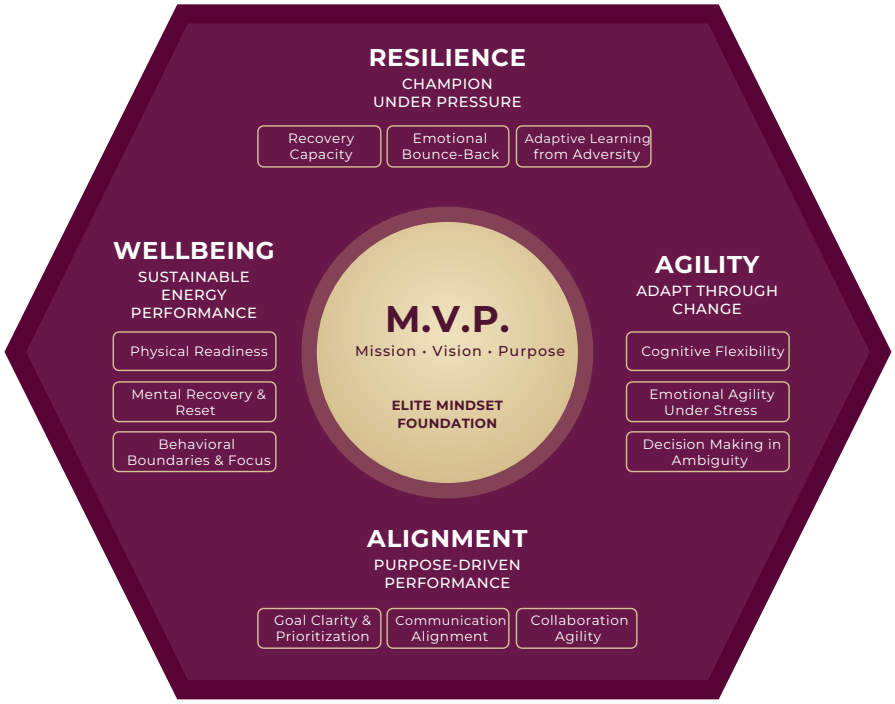
The person you manage who is taking the Athleader track. You're their Player-Coach: you lead your own season and coach them through theirs.

Two roles, one season

Lead self, then lead others. Every lesson has one drill for your own leadership and one or two for coaching your Athleader and your team.

The shared language: A.R.A.W. (Core 4)

Your Athleader conditions the same four leadership muscles you do. Using the same words is half of coaching them.



Agility. My ability to adapt to change, pivot quickly, and make decisions under pressure.

Resilience. My ability to bounce back from setbacks, manage stress, and maintain a positive mindset.

Alignment. My ability to align my daily actions with my deeper purpose and values, and to communicate clearly with my team.

Wellbeing. My ability to manage my energy, prioritize recovery, and sustain high performance without burnout.

GETTING STARTED

How your Playbook works

Each lesson has its own Playbook file. You'll find it on the lesson's **Condition the Reps** screen, near the end of the lesson, and in the course's Resources list. The whole season is also available in one file, if you'd rather keep everything together. Pick one way and keep your answers in it.

Every lesson's pages follow the same order:

1. **Pre-Game Huddle.** The lesson's focus, its objectives, and where to start.
2. **A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills.** One core rep, marked "start here," and extra reps if you have time. Lead self first, then lead others. Each one shows about how long it takes.
3. **Locker Room Reflection.** The lesson's real-world challenge, your notes, and the feedback you asked for.

Your season at a glance

Lesson	Your core rep	Core	All reps
1 Suit Up: Your Leadership M.V.P.	1.4 Your Starting Line	30 min	50 min
2 The Leader's Scouting Report	2.4 Forward-looking feedback	20 min	60 min
3 The 90-Day Way Game Plan	3.2 Your 90-day game plan	20 min	50 min
4 Activate Your M.V.P. Under Pressure	4.4 The agility question	15 min	40 min
5 Play the Season	5.2 Your energy audit	15 min	55 min
6 The Victory Lap and the Next Season	6.3 Championship Conversation	30 min	60 min

About an hour a week: your lesson, then one core rep, often a conversation you would hold anyway. Extra reps are there when you have more time.

Filling it in

- Type straight into the grey boxes, and tick the boxes that apply.
- Save the file to keep your answers. In a browser, use the download or save button. In Acrobat or Preview, use Save.
- Prefer paper? Print the pages and write by hand.
- Only you see what you write. Nothing in this file is sent anywhere.

Your 90-Day Way Scorecard is a separate file, for your own 90-day leadership goal. You set it in Lesson 3 and track it week by week. It's in the course's Resources list.

GETTING STARTED

Set Up Your Season

Four things to do before Lesson 1. Check off each one as you complete it.

- [ ] **Take your Benchmark Pre-Assessment.** It takes about five minutes, in the course, and you take the same one at the end of your season.

- [ ] **Save your Playbook** somewhere you'll find it again: this file now, and each lesson's pages as you reach them.

- [ ] **Book the Starting Line with your Athleader.** Your first 30-minute conversation. You're the one who books it, ideally this week. The Commitment and Starting Line agenda is in the Resources list, and Drill 1.4 helps you prepare.

My Athleader: _____ Meeting date: _____

- [ ] **Block about an hour a week:** your lesson, then one core rep. Same time each week. Move it when you need to, as long as you keep it.

Day: _____ Time: _____

"I am a manager who manages several participants."

Great. This journey supports your growth and your team's. If you manage multiple participants, hold one 30-minute Starting Line with each person at the start. After that, build the 15-minute check-ins into your existing meeting rhythm. No need to create additional meetings.





THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 1

Suit Up: Your Leadership M.V.P.

About 50 minutes of reps this week. Your core rep, Drill 1.4, is the Starting Line: 30 minutes with your Athleader.

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LESSON 1 · GOES WITH VIDEO 1.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 1

Welcome to your first week, Player-Coach. This week is about laying the foundation for a successful season by establishing your role, your own intention, and a clear, committed partnership with your Athleader.

"The foundation of every great team is a clear, committed partnership between the player and the Player-Coach."

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

Alignment Wellbeing

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Understand your role as a Player-Coach in the Athleadership model.
- Define your own "Player-Coach Intention" with a focus on your wellbeing and leadership growth.
- Identify a key "Manager Multiplier" opportunity with your Athleader.
- Facilitate a structured Starting Line to create a foundation of trust and clarity.

Ground Your Intention

Review the two questions you reflected on at the start of this lesson. Keep them front and center as you complete these drills to ensure your work is targeted and meaningful.

What is one leadership behavior you want to strengthen for yourself?

What is one leadership behavior you want to improve in how you support your team's performance?

START HERE

Drill 1.4: Your Starting Line

Your core rep this week, about 30 minutes.

Page 13 ›

LESSON 1 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep is the Starting Line with your Athleader.

Drill 1.2

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Define Your Player-Coach Intention

Alignment · lead self

10 min

Page 11 ›

Drill 1.3

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Identify the Multiplier Effect

Alignment · lead others

10 min

Page 12 ›

Drill 1.4

CORE REP · START HERE

The First Conversation: Your Starting Line

Alignment · lead others

30 min

Page 13 ›

Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how it landed.

Drill 1.2 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 1.2

LEAD SELF: Define Your Player-Coach Intention

Great coaching starts with self-awareness. Before you can guide your Athleader, you need to know what you want out of this experience for your own growth. This is your first step in leading yourself (Alignment and Wellbeing), so you can more effectively lead others.

Step 1

Identify Your Pressure Point

What is one specific pressure point (e.g., tight deadlines, team conflict, managing up) you are currently facing in your role? *This helps you focus on a real-world challenge where you can apply what you are learning immediately.*

Step 2

Define Your Wellbeing Practice

What is one wellbeing practice (e.g., taking a 15-minute walk at lunch, ending the workday at a set time, delegating one task) you can implement this week to manage that pressure and perform sustainably? *This is your first A.R.A.W. check-in, connecting wellbeing directly to performance.*

3. State Your Intention

Combine your reflections into a single, powerful intention statement. This intention will be your anchor for this season, and you will share it with your Athleader at your Starting Line.

My intention for this M.V.P. Accelerator season is to

Drill 1.3 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 1.3

LEAD OTHERS: Identify the Multiplier Effect

Your leadership is a catalyst. This drill helps you strategically focus your coaching on the area where your Athleader's growth will have the biggest ripple effect on the team and business, maximizing the "Manager Multiplier Effect."

Step 1

Identify a Growth Area

What is one area of growth for your Athleader (e.g., technical skill, presentation skills, cross-functional collaboration) that, if improved, would have the largest positive impact on the rest of the team?

Step 2

Connect to a Business Goal

How does this growth area connect to one of your team's key business goals for this quarter? *This creates clear alignment between individual development and business outcomes.*

Step 3

Align with Stakeholders

Have you translated direction from your senior leaders into clear, actionable steps for your team related to this? How could you align stakeholders outside of your immediate team to support this goal? *This drill links to the assessment theme of organizational alignment and ensuring your team understands the "why" behind their work.*

Drill 1.4 | Core rep · start here | About 30 minutes · Goes with Video 1.4

LEAD OTHERS: The First Conversation, Your Starting Line

This meeting is the single most important play call of this lesson. It moves your relationship from one of unspoken assumptions to one of explicit, aligned partnership.

Bring the Commitment and Starting Line agenda (in the Resources list). It follows the five parts below. The lines from this Playbook help you prepare what you'll say.

With: _____ Date: _____ Time: _____

Step 1

Arrive (5 min)

What are you walking into this experience carrying right now? One word is enough. Share more if you want to.

Your Opening

"Thanks for meeting. I'm excited to go on this journey with you as a partnership. While you're going through the Athleader track, I'm going through this Player-Coach track to become a better Player-Coach for you and the team."

My word: _____

Step 2

Name the Win (10 min)

Athleader: 90 days from now, what do you want to be different in how you lead? Player-Coach: if that change is happening, what might you notice? Then switch. Player-Coach: what do you want to strengthen in how you lead over these 90 days? Athleader: if that change is happening, what might I experience differently?

Sharing Intentions

"Thank you for sharing. My intention as your Player-Coach is [share your intention from Drill 1.2]. I'm sharing this because I want us to hold each other accountable and be partners in this growth." Listen intently. Ask clarifying questions like, "What makes that so important to you right now?" or "What would achieving that unlock for you?"

What I want to strengthen in how I lead over these 90 days:

Step 3

Get Honest (5 min)

When things get busy, what are you each most likely to stop doing first? No judgment. Know your pattern. What will help you come back?

My pattern, and what helps me come back:

Step 4

Name What You Need (5 min)

What do you need from each other for this experience to matter? And one agreement: can we give each other honest perspective, even when it may be easier not to?

Support and Psychological Safety

Ask for needs: "What is the most important thing you need from me to feel supported and safe to take risks on this journey?" This question directly addresses the core competency of creating psychological safety, a key theme in your assessment. State your needs: "To be the best Player-Coach I can be for you, what I need is [e.g., for you to be proactive in sharing your insights, for you to be open when you face a challenge]. This will help us build a strong foundation of trust."

What I need from my Athleader:

Step 5

Set the Rhythm (5 min)

When will we check in? Put your next conversation on the calendar now. Then decide: if we lose the rhythm, how will we call each other back in? That's your reset.

Set the Rhythm

"Let's set up a recurring 15-minute check-in specifically for this experience. This will be our dedicated time to connect on your progress. Let's get it on the calendar now."

Our check-in, day: _____ Time: _____

Our reset: _____

☐ We signed Our Commitment together, at the end of the Starting Line.

"I am a manager who manages several participants."

Great. This journey supports your growth and your team's. If you manage multiple participants, hold one 30-minute Starting Line with each person at the start. After that, build the 15-minute check-ins into your existing meeting rhythm. No need to create additional meetings.



"Great leaders don't wait for change; they create it."

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge: During your Starting Line, your Athleader seems hesitant and gives very general answers about their goals. How do you apply the principle of psychological safety to encourage openness without applying pressure? What specific question could you ask to build trust?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 1.4.

My notes:

Get Feedback

Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how it landed.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with Tracey Newell, then your Pulse Check.



THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 2

The Leader’s Scouting Report

About 60 minutes of reps this week. Your core rep, Drill 2.4, takes about 20, inside a check-in you’d hold anyway.

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LESSON 2 · GOES WITH VIDEO 2.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 2

Welcome to Lesson 2. This week is about data: not spreadsheets, but the human data that drives performance. Your Athleader is creating their "Inner Blueprint" by defining their M.V.P.+V (Mission, Vision, Purpose + Values).

Your role is to help them analyze this data with curiosity, while also conducting an honest scouting report on yourself.

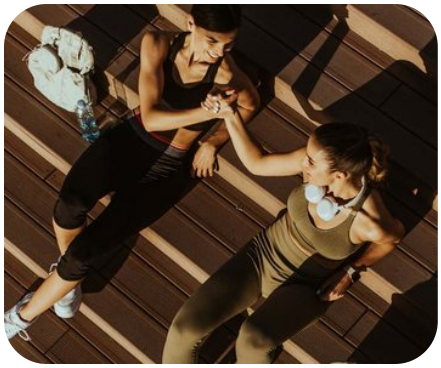
"You can't coach what you can't see. The best coaches see the potential inside a player before the player sees it in themselves."

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

Alignment Resilience

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Define your own non-negotiable leadership M.V.P.+V to create a shared language with your Athleader.
- Practice coaching techniques that foster psychological safety.
- Prepare to use the "Forward-Looking Feedback" framework to make feedback developmental, not judgmental.



Did You Know?

According to a Gallup poll, being ignored by a manager can be more detrimental to an employee's engagement than receiving negative feedback. This lesson gives you the tools to engage meaningfully.

Source: Gallup, "Driving Engagement by Focusing on Strengths" (news.gallup.com/businessjournal/124214).

START HERE

Drill 2.4: The Forward-Looking Feedback Framework Page 23 ›

Your core rep this week, about 20 minutes.

LESSON 2 · ABOUT 60 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep happens inside a check-in you'd hold anyway.

Drill 2.2

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Your Leadership M.V.P.+V Scouting Report

Alignment · lead self

30 min

Page 20 ›

Drill 2.3

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Coaching for Psychological Safety

Resilience · lead others

10 min

Page 22 ›

Drill 2.4

CORE REP · START HERE

The Forward-Looking Feedback Framework

Alignment · lead others

20 min

Page 23 ›

Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how it landed.

Drill 2.2 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 30 minutes · Goes with Video 2.2

LEAD SELF: Your Leadership M.V.P.+V Scouting Report

Your Athleader is defining their Inner Blueprint. To be an effective Player-Coach, you need your own playbook. This drill is a streamlined, high-impact version of your Athleader's M.V.P. work, designed to give you clarity on your own leadership identity (Alignment), and it prepares you for the assessment questions on this topic.

Part 1: Your Core Values

Your values are your non-negotiable principles that guide your decisions under pressure. Brainstorm 10 to 15 values that are important to you, then force-rank them to identify your essential Core 3.

My brainstorm:

My Core Values:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Part 2: Architecting Your M.V.P.

My Purpose (My "Why"): What is the fundamental reason your leadership matters? What is the lasting impact you want to have on the people you lead?

My Vision (My "Where"): What is the vivid picture of the future you are creating for your team and your own career over the next one to three years? What does winning look like?

My Mission (My "How"): What do you do every day to make your vision a reality? How do you operationalize your purpose?

Template: I will [ACTION] for [AUDIENCE] by [FOCUS AREA] to [RESULT].

Part 3: Alignment Reflection

How can you use this M.V.P. statement in your next team meeting to better align your team's priorities with a sense of purpose?

Drill 2.3 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 2.3

LEAD OTHERS: Coaching for Psychological Safety

This week, your task is to create a safe space for your Athleader to share their insights and challenges beyond status updates. This builds the trust necessary for true development.

In your next check-in with your Athleader, your goal is to ask one of the following open-ended, non-judgmental questions and then listen to the answer without immediately trying to solve it. Your role here is to be curious, not to fix.



Check the one you'll ask:

- ☐ "What's been the most surprising insight for you in this self-discovery process so far?"
- ☐ "As you've been reflecting on your values, what's felt most energizing or even challenging?"
- ☐ "What part of this Inner Blueprint work feels most relevant to the challenges you're facing right now?"

✎ What they said, and what you noticed when you listened without fixing:

"If your team can't tell you the truth, they'll protect you from problems instead of helping you solve them."

Drill 2.4 | Core rep · start here | About 20 minutes · Goes with Video 2.4

LEAD OTHERS: The Forward-Looking Feedback Framework

This three-step framework is designed to make your next feedback conversation more impactful and less intimidating for both you and your Athleader. It shifts the focus from past mistakes to future growth.

Think of one piece of feedback (either positive or constructive) you need to give your Athleader. Plan your specific language for each step using the playbook below. *Then use the three steps in your next check-in, and notice whether your habit is to analyze the past or build the next move.*

Step 1

Acknowledge (Validate the Effort)

How will you start by validating their effort, intent, or the situation? This lowers defensiveness.

Your Planned Opening

Example: "I want to acknowledge the hard work you put into..." or "I recognize the pressure you were under when..."

Step 2

Connect (Bridge to the Future)

What future-focused question will you ask to connect the past event to a future opportunity?

Your Connecting Question

Example: "Based on that experience, what's one lesson we can apply to the upcoming project?" or "Thinking ahead, how might we approach a similar situation differently to get an even better outcome?"

Step 3

Co-Create (Empower Ownership)

How will you empower them to own the next step? This turns feedback into an action plan: one small action, with a date.

Your Co-Created Next Step

Example: "What's one small action you think you could take this week based on this?" or "What support do you need from me to make that happen?"

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge: You notice your Athleader is only sharing positive updates and successes. How can you gently create an opening for them to discuss challenges, reinforcing that this is a safe space for growth, not just performance reporting? What specific question might you ask?

Self-Scouting: What is your default tendency in feedback conversations: to analyze and critique the past or to focus on co-creating the future? How will using this framework require a shift in your approach?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 2.4.

My notes:

Get Feedback

Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how it landed.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with LaChina Robinson, then your Pulse Check.



THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 3

The 90-Day Way Game Plan

About 50 minutes of reps this week. Your core rep, Drill 3.2, your own game plan, takes about 20.

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LESSON 3 · GOES WITH VIDEO 3.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 3

Welcome to Lesson 3. This is where the M.V.P. Blueprint moves from a strategic document to a tactical, executable plan. Your Athleader is building their first 90-Day Plan to translate their purpose into focused action.

Your role is to be their crucial Alignment check, ensuring their plan is both ambitious and achievable. You will also model the focus you expect by building your own plan.

> **"An amateur has a goal. A professional has a system."**
>
> James Clear

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

Agility | Alignment | Resilience

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Draft your own tactical 90-Day Leadership Plan to model focus and clarity.
- Learn how to introduce the 90-Day Way framework as a team alignment tool.
- Prepare to coach your team through the inevitable roadblocks and skepticism that come with any new plan.



Did You Know?

Research on New Year's resolutions suggests 92% of people never achieve their goals. The difference isn't the goal itself, but having a system to execute consistently. The 90-Day Way is that system.

Source: University of Scranton research, as reported in Psychology Today, "92 Percent of People Never Achieve Their Goals" (December 2024).

START HERE

Drill 3.2: Your 90-Day Game Plan

Your core rep this week, about 20 minutes.

Page 28 ›

LESSON 3 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep is your own game plan, so you model the focus you ask for.

Drill 3.2

CORE REP · START HERE

Your 90-Day Game Plan

Agility · lead self

20 min

Page 28 ›

Drill 3.3

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Introducing the 90-Day Way

Alignment · lead others

20 min

Page 29 ›

Drill 3.4

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Coaching Through Skepticism and Roadblocks

Resilience · lead others

10 min

Page 30 ›

Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Share your goal with your Athleader in this week's check-in.

Drill 3.2 | Core rep · start here | About 20 minutes · Goes with Video 3.2

LEAD SELF: Your 90-Day Game Plan

You cannot lead a team with a clear game plan if you haven't defined one for yourself. This drill moves you from theory to action, forcing you to gain clarity on your leadership priorities for the coming quarter. Use this template to architect your focus.

Complete the template below. Start by anchoring your goal in your M.V.P. statement from Lesson 2.

Step 1

M.V.P. Anchor

Review your M.V.P. from Drill 2.2. How does this goal serve your Purpose, Vision, or Mission?

Step 2

My #1 Leadership Goal for the Next 90 Days

What is the single most important leadership behavior or outcome you want to achieve? Be specific: about how you lead, measurable, with a start date.

Step 3

A.R.A.W. Pillar Under Pressure

Which Core 4 pillar will this goal test the most? This helps you anticipate where you'll need to focus your energy.

- ◯ **Agility** — Requires adapting to new information or changing priorities.
- ◯ **Resilience** — Requires bouncing back from a setback or managing stress.
- ◯ **Alignment** — Requires getting buy-in from others or connecting to a larger strategy.
- ◯ **Wellbeing** — Requires managing your energy, prioritizing recovery, and preventing burnout.

Step 4

The #1 Anticipated Roadblock

What is the biggest obstacle, internal or external, that could derail this goal?

Step 5

My Proactive Reframe Plan

How will you proactively address this roadblock? What powerful question can you ask yourself to reframe it as an opportunity?

- ☐ I added this goal to my 90-Day Way Scorecard.
- ☐ I'll share it with my Athleader in this week's check-in.

Drill 3.3 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 20 minutes · Goes with Video 3.3

LEAD OTHERS: Introducing the 90-Day Way

Your play is to introduce the 90-Day Way framework to your team, not as another initiative, but as a tool to build shared focus and reduce noise. This drill helps you prepare your talking points for maximum impact.

Plan your talking points for your next team meeting using the playbook below.

Step 1

The "Why" (Your Benefit Statement)

How will you explain the benefit of this framework to the team? Frame it as a solution to a shared pain point.

Your "Why" Statement

Example

"To help us cut through the noise of competing priorities and protect our focus, we're going to try a simple framework called the 90-Day Way. This is a tool to help us clarify what truly matters this quarter so we can make a real impact and feel less stretched."

Step 2

The Facilitation Question

What is the one powerful, open-ended question you will ask to start the conversation about a shared 90-day goal?

Your Facilitation Question

Example

"Looking at our key priorities, what is the one thing that, if we achieve it this quarter, will make the biggest difference for our customers and the business?"

In the video, Melissa's question is: "What is the one thing we must achieve this quarter to be successful?" Then open every weekly check-in with the answer.

Our shared goal:

We review it: _____

Drill 3.4 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 3.4

LEAD OTHERS: Coaching Through Skepticism and Roadblocks

Your role as a Player-Coach is to build your team's Resilience by helping them anticipate and reframe obstacles. This drill prepares you for two common challenges: skepticism and roadblocks.

Part 1: Coaching Through Skepticism

You introduce the 90-Day Way, and a team member expresses skepticism, seeing it as "just another corporate initiative that will fade." How do you address their concern and build buy-in? *Hint: connect it to a pain point they are feeling, like meeting overload or unclear priorities.*

Your Response Plan

Part 2: The Roadblock Reframe

Anticipate a potential roadblock for your team's new 90-day goal and prepare a powerful coaching question to spark creative problem-solving instead of defeat.

Anticipated Roadblock

e.g., a budget cut, a shifting deadline, a key dependency is delayed.

Your Powerful Question

This question should shift the team from "we can't" to "how could we?"

Example

"This is a tough constraint. What new possibilities or creative solutions does this force us to consider?"

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge: A new, urgent corporate priority drops in the middle of your team's 90-day plan. How do you use the 90-Day Way framework to help your team adapt with Agility, reassess priorities without losing momentum, and manage their Wellbeing to prevent burnout?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 3.4.

"Align your focus, act with intention, and watch results compound. That's the 90-Day Way in action."

My notes:

Get Feedback

Share your goal with your Athleader in this week's check-in, and ask about the purpose they're defining.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with Stephanie Johnson, then your Pulse Check.



THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 4

Activate Your M.V.P. Under Pressure

About 40 minutes of reps this week. Your core rep, Drill 4.4, the agility question, happens inside one real conversation.

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LESSON 4 · GOES WITH VIDEO 4.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 4

Welcome to Lesson 4. A plan is just a theory until it meets reality. This week is about activating your M.V.P. when it matters most, when the pressure is on and the stakes are high.

This is where leadership is truly revealed and conditioned, and where your Resilience and Agility are tested.

> **"Pressure is a privilege. It only comes to those who have earned it."**
>
> Billie Jean King

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

Resilience Agility

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Develop your personal "Resilience Playbook" to consciously manage your reactions under stress.
- Learn to diagnose the root cause of resistance to change within your team.
- Practice coaching for agility to help your Athleader and team pivot effectively.



START HERE

Drill 4.4: The Agility Coaching Question

Your core rep this week, about 15 minutes.

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LESSON 4 · ABOUT 40 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep happens inside one real conversation this week.

Drill 4.2

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Your Resilience Playbook

Resilience · lead self

10 min

Page 35 ›

Drill 4.3

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Diagnosing Resistance to Change

Agility · lead others

15 min

Page 36 ›

Drill 4.4

CORE REP · START HERE

The Agility Coaching Question

Agility · lead others

15 min

Page 37 ›

Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Complete your core rep, then ask the person you coached how it landed.

Drill 4.2 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 4.2

LEAD SELF: Your Resilience Playbook

Your team's resilience is a direct reflection of your own. An emotionally regulated leader promotes psychological safety and clear thinking. This drill helps you move from being reactive to being responsive by defining your go-to plays for staying calm and focused under pressure.

Identify two or three common stress triggers and design a specific "Resilience Play" for each.

Common Stress Trigger What is a recurring situation at work that causes you to feel stressed, overwhelmed, or reactive?	**My "Resilience Play"** What is one simple, immediate action you can take to create a pause between the trigger and your reaction?	**A.R.A.W. Pillar Strengthened** Wellbeing, Resilience, etc.
Example *Receiving an unexpected, critical email from a senior leader.*	**Example** *Stand up, walk to get water. Do not reply for at least 10 minutes.*	**Example** *Wellbeing / Resilience*

Your First Move

In the video, a CEO puts 10 minutes between the news and her response. Write your own first move.

What triggers it: _____

What I'll do for 10 minutes: _____

Where I'll do it: _____

Drill 4.3 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 15 minutes · Goes with Video 4.3

LEAD OTHERS: Diagnosing Resistance to Change

Resistance to change is rarely about the change itself; it's about a perceived loss. Your play as a Player-Coach is to listen beyond the surface-level complaints to diagnose what your team fears they will lose. Understanding this is the key to unlocking buy-in.

Think of a recent change you led (or are currently leading). Analyze the resistance to identify the primary root fear.

Step 1

The Change Initiative

Briefly describe the change.

Step 2

The Root Fear

Based on your team's questions and behaviors, what was the primary fear driving resistance? Check the most dominant one and provide your evidence below.

- ☐ **Loss of Certainty** (fear of the unknown, ambiguity, lack of a clear plan)
- ☐ **Loss of Competence** (fear of not being able to adapt, learn new skills, or succeed in the new environment)
- ☐ **Loss of Connection** (fear of a change to team dynamics, relationships, or informal networks)

Evidence / Observations

What did you see or hear that points to this specific fear?

Coaching Corner

Understanding this fundamentally changes how you will lead the next change. How can you proactively address this specific fear the next time you introduce a new initiative? *Write the questions you'll ask in a one-on-one.*

Drill 4.4 | Core rep · start here | About 15 minutes · Goes with Video 4.4

LEAD OTHERS: The Agility Coaching Question

A Player-Coach who always provides the answer creates dependency. A Player-Coach who asks powerful questions builds Agility. Your role is to build your Athleader's capacity to solve problems by shifting from "problem-solver-in-chief" to "question-asker."

Add the following powerful question to your coaching toolkit. The next time your Athleader brings you a problem, resist the urge to solve it and make this your first response.

"That's a tough challenge. What's your initial read on a path forward?"

Your Go-To Agility Question

Or the question from the lesson, when a constraint lands:

"What does this new constraint make possible?"

Practice Plan

Identify a specific, upcoming situation or meeting where you can practice using this question this week.

Situation / Person

Reflection: How does asking this question first, instead of providing a solution, change the dynamic of the conversation?

Your core rep: use it in one real conversation and note what changed when you asked a question instead of providing a solution.

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge and Self-Scouting: When you are under pressure, does your team see you as a source of calm or a source of stress? What is one specific behavior you can change this week (leveraging your Resilience Playbook from Drill 4.2) to better model resilience and composure for your team?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 4.4.

My notes:

Get Feedback

Complete your core rep, then ask the person you coached how it landed.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with Dr. Michael Mannino, then your Pulse Check.



THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 5

Play the Season, Sustainable Performance

About 55 minutes of reps this week. Your core rep, Drill 5.2, your energy audit, takes about 15.

M.V.P. Accelerator™

POWERED BY ATHLEADERSHIP ARENA™

LESSON 5 · GOES WITH VIDEO 5.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 5

Welcome to Lesson 5. We are deep into the season, where cumulative fatigue can derail even the best plans. This lesson is about the science of sustainable high performance.

The best Athleaders and coaches know that victory depends on managing Wellbeing and energy, not just time. Your role is to model these sustainable practices to ensure you and your team can finish the season strong and avoid burnout.

"Rest isn't a bug; it's a feature of high performance. It's the strategic pause that fuels the next sprint."

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

Wellbeing | Alignment

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Conduct a personal "Energy Audit" to identify and manage your key energy drains and sources.
- Learn to consciously model sustainable work practices to influence your team's culture.
- Develop a proactive plan for facilitating team recovery after intense periods of effort.



The Science of Performance

Management writer Sylvia Ann Hewlett found that 35% of high earners worked more than 60 hours a week, and 10% more than 80. A Stanford study found that working longer hours doesn't make people more productive. This lesson provides the tactical plays to counter this trend.

Sources: Sylvia Ann Hewlett, as cited by Morten Hansen (mortenhansen.com); CNBC (March 2019) on John Pencavel's research at Stanford.

START HERE

Drill 5.2: The Personal Energy Audit

Your core rep this week, about 15 minutes.

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LESSON 5 · ABOUT 55 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep is your own energy, because your team copies what you do.

Drill 5.2

CORE REP · START HERE

The Personal Energy Audit

Wellbeing · lead self

15 min

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Drill 5.3

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Modeling Sustainable Practices

Wellbeing · lead others

10 min

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Drill 5.4

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

The Team Recovery Protocol

Alignment · lead others

30 min

Page 44 ›

Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Complete your core rep, then ask one person how it landed.

Drill 5.2 | Core rep · start here | About 15 minutes · Goes with Video 5.2

LEAD SELF: The Personal Energy Audit

The most effective leaders are masters of energy management. Time is finite, but energy is renewable if managed correctly. This drill helps you gather data on your personal energy drains and fuel sources so you can optimize your performance.

For one full workday this week, use the log below to track your energy. At several points during the day, note the activity you were just doing and how it made you feel.

My Daily Energy Audit Log

Activity / Meeting / Task	Time of Day	Energy level after (mark one)		
e.g., Team Budget Review Meeting	*e.g., 10 a.m.*	Drained	Neutral	Energized
		○	○	○
		○	○	○
		○	○	○
		○	○	○
		○	○	○
		○	○	○

Analysis and Action Plan

1. My Biggest Energy Giver Was

What single activity had the most positive impact on your energy?

2. My Biggest Energy Drainer Was

What single activity had the most negative impact on your energy?

3. One Change I Will Make

Based on this audit, what is one specific change you can make to your schedule or workflow next week to minimize a drain or maximize a giver?

The block I'll protect next week (day, time): _____

Drill 5.3 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 10 minutes · Goes with Video 5.3

LEAD OTHERS: Modeling Sustainable Practices

Your habits create your team's norms. The phrase "do as I say, not as I do" is the quickest way to lose credibility as a leader. Your play is to consciously model one behavior that sends a powerful signal to your team that Wellbeing is a non-negotiable part of high performance.

Choose one of the following plays to run consistently this week. Check the box to commit to it.

- ☐ **The "Schedule Send" Play** Use the "schedule send" feature for all emails written after 6 p.m., ensuring they arrive during business hours the next day.
- ☐ **The Full Break** Take a full lunch break, completely away from your desk and email, and encourage your team to do the same.
- ☐ **The Disconnect Praise** Explicitly praise a team member for taking their vacation time and fully disconnecting, reinforcing that rest is valued.
- ☐ **The Gift of Time** Proactively end a meeting you are leading 5-10 minutes early, explicitly giving everyone back time to transition.



✎ The sentence you'll use to introduce it to your team:

✎ Reflection: Why is modeling one of these behaviors more powerful than simply telling your team to "take care of their wellbeing"?

Drill 5.4 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 30 minutes · Goes with Video 5.4

LEAD OTHERS: The Team Recovery Protocol

In sports, recovery isn't optional; it's a strategic part of the training cycle. The same is true for elite teams in business. Your play is to proactively plan for your team's recovery before they hit the wall after their next big push.

Complete the Team Recovery Protocol Planner below, and then schedule the recovery event on the team calendar now. This makes it real.

Step 1

Identify the Next Big Push

What is the next major deadline, project launch, or intense period for your team?

Project / Deadline: _____ Target Date: _____

Step 2

Schedule a Recovery Protocol

What is one small but meaningful thing you can do as a team within a few days of that date to acknowledge the effort and facilitate recovery?

My Team's Recovery Protocol

Example

A celebratory team lunch, a "no-meetings" afternoon, a retrospective focused only on lessons learned and celebrating wins, a half day for professional development.

In the video, the order is: celebrate the wins, capture the lessons, give something back. Then plan.

Wins to celebrate: _____

Lessons to capture: _____

What we'll give back: _____

- [ ] It's on the team calendar.

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge: What is one “unwritten rule” or implicit expectation on your team that might be contributing to a culture of burnout (e.g., everyone stays online late, instant Teams/Slack responses are expected, lunch is eaten at the desk)? What is one specific step you can take as the leader to begin to change it?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 5.4.



“Recovery isn’t a pause from performance. It’s the rhythm that makes sustained performance possible.”

My notes:

Get Feedback

Complete your core rep, then ask one person how it landed.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with Ryall Graber, then your Pulse Check.



THE PLAYER-COACH PLAYBOOK

Lesson 6

The Victory Lap and the Next Season

About 60 minutes this week. Your core rep, Drill 6.3, is the Championship Conversation with your Athleader.

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LESSON 6 · GOES WITH VIDEO 6.1

Pre-Game Huddle: Your Focus for Lesson 6

Welcome to your final lesson, Player-Coach. This isn't just an ending; it's a commencement. It's about celebrating the progress you and your Athleader have made, solidifying the learning to ensure it sticks, and intentionally planning for what comes next.

A true victory isn't just finishing the experience; it's using the momentum to fuel the next season of growth.

"The final whistle of one season is the starting pistol for the next. Celebrate the win, but never forget what it takes to win again."

This week's A.R.A.W. focus:

All four

Your Objectives for this Lesson:

- Reflect on and create a system to cement your own new leadership habits.
- Master the "Championship Conversation" to celebrate your Athleader's success and provide career-accelerating visibility.
- Create a clear coaching plan for your Athleader's next 90-day season of growth.



START HERE

Drill 6.3: The Championship Conversation

Your core rep this week, about 30 minutes.

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LESSON 6 · ABOUT 60 MINUTES OF REPS THIS WEEK

A.R.A.W. Conditioning Drills

Lead self first, then lead others. Your core rep is the conversation that makes your Athleader's season visible.

Drill 6.2

EXTRA REP, IF YOU HAVE TIME

Cementing Your Leadership Habits

All four · lead self

15 min

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Drill 6.3

CORE REP · START HERE

The Championship Conversation

Alignment · lead others

30 min

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Assessment

REQUIRED · AT THE END OF THIS LESSON

Your post-assessment and your 180

All four · in the course

20 min

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Fill it in on screen. Type straight into the grey boxes and tick the boxes that apply. Save the file to keep your answers.

Or on paper. Print the pages and write by hand.

Then get feedback. Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how the conversation went.

Drill 6.2 | Extra rep, if you have time | About 15 minutes · Goes with Video 6.2

LEAD SELF: Cementing Your Leadership Habits

The goal of this experience was to help you build new leadership habits, not just learn new ideas. This drill is about making them permanent by building a system around your most impactful new practice.

My Leadership Habit Integration Plan

Step 1

Identify Your Most Impactful New Habit

Look back through this Playbook. What is the one new practice or framework (e.g., the Energy Audit, the Agility Coaching Question, the Forward-Looking Feedback model) that has been most valuable for you as a leader?

Step 2

Schedule the Habit (Build Your System)

How will you build a system to ensure this practice continues? Be specific about the trigger and the schedule.

My System

Recurring slot: _____

Trigger: _____

Someone who'd notice if I stopped: _____

Example

If it were the Energy Audit, your system might be: "Every Friday at 2 p.m. (my trigger), I will block 15 minutes on my calendar (my system) to review the week's energy and plan for the next."

In the video, a practice lasts when it has a recurring slot, a clear trigger, and someone who'd notice if you stopped. Choose one or two.

Drill 6.3 | Core rep · start here | About 30 minutes · Goes with Videos 6.3 and 6.4

LEAD OTHERS: The Championship Conversation

This is your final, most important play call. Your task is to hold the Championship Conversation, designed to make your Athleader's success visible and sustainable. This playbook breaks it down into three critical parts.

Part 1: CELEBRATE

Recognition fuels motivation. How will you acknowledge your Athleader's growth and commitment? Check all that apply and add your ideas.

Ask how they like to be recognized first. Some people want public praise, and others would rather hear it privately.

- [ ] Acknowledge their specific growth and contribution in our next team meeting.
- [ ] Send a recognition email highlighting their key accomplishment to our team and key stakeholders.
- [ ] Nominate them for a formal company award or recognition program.
- [ ] Thank them one-on-one, in the way they prefer, naming a specific project.

My Own Idea

Part 2: PROVIDE Visibility

Advocacy accelerates careers. This is a key theme from your assessment. How will you use your influence to give them exposure to senior leadership?

A key senior leader: _____

Who is one leader whose awareness of your Athleader's work would be beneficial for their career?

Plan the connection. Choose your play:

- ☐ **The Introduction** Schedule a brief, informal 15-minute virtual coffee for the three of us.
- ☐ **The Strategic Update** Send a concise note or email to that leader highlighting your Athleader's key accomplishment and how it ties to a broader business goal.

✎ The Message: What is the one key accomplishment or new skill you want to highlight?

Part 3: PLAN the Next Season: Your Athleader's Next 90-Day Focus

Momentum is built on a clear vision for what's next. Prepare your key coaching question for your final check-in this season.



"This was a great season of growth. Based on everything you've learned and accomplished, what is your primary focus or #1 goal for your next 90-day season?"

✎ Capture Their Goal

Listen and capture their response here. This becomes the foundation for your coaching conversations next quarter.

Locker Room Reflection

Challenge: Of the three plays in the Championship Conversation (Celebrate, Provide Visibility, and Plan the Next Season), which one do you believe will have the most significant long-term impact on your Athleader's career momentum and engagement at the company, and why?

This reflection goes with the real-world challenge from Video 6.4.



"What you do daily determines who you become permanently."

My notes:

Get Feedback

Complete your core rep, then ask your Athleader how the conversation went.

Who I asked: _____

What they said, and what I'll keep doing:

Back in the course: your Athleader Pro Huddle with Sagar Pandya, your Pulse Check, then your post-assessment and your 180.

FINAL STEPS

Your “Next Play”

You’ve coached a full season. Three steps close it in the course.

- [ ] **Complete your post-assessment.** The same questions you answered before Lesson 1. Your Growth Guide comes with your results.
- [ ] **Complete your 180.** Your view of how your Athleader has grown, while they give their view of how you supported them. Think about the moments you saw them lead differently this season.
- [ ] **Pay it forward on the Wall of Fame.** Share one moment from your season that showed you what had changed, or one thing you’d tell the next Player-Coach.

My notes:

Draft your few lines for the Wall of Fame here.



Thank you for coaching your Athleader through this season, and for doing your own work alongside them. That’s what a Player-Coach is. You’ve got this!



Melissa Dawn Simkins
Founder, Athleadership, and Head Coach